



AA Legal

...Committed to excellence!!!

A comprehensive overview of the end-to-end operations of a modern Canadian legal practice — from the first client enquiry to file closure and beyond.

DOCUMENT

Business Operations Manual

FIRM

AA Legal — Calgary, AB

PRINCIPAL

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EDITION

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SECTION 01 — IDENTITY

Who We Are & What We Stand For

AA Legal is a Calgary-based law firm built on three pillars:

Professionalism, Integrity, and Compassion. We serve individuals, families, and businesses across Alberta with a full suite of legal services delivered with the warmth of a community practice and the rigor of a corporate firm.

Mission

To provide accessible, ethical, and outcome-driven legal services that protect our clients' rights, assets, and futures — at every life stage and through every transaction.

Vision

To be Alberta's most trusted boutique law firm — recognised for excellence in client care, technological sophistication, and community contribution.

Core Values

- ✓ Professionalism in every interaction
- ✓ Integrity above expediency
- ✓ Compassion for clients' circumstances
- ✓ Confidentiality & privilege protection
- ✓ Continuous learning & modernization
- ✓ Community service & pro-bono work

SECTION 02 — SERVICE LINES

Our Five Areas of Practice

Each practice area is supported by structured intake, dedicated workflows, precedent libraries, and clear fee structures.



Family Law

Divorce & separation, custody & parenting, child & spousal support, division of property, prenuptial & cohabitation agreements, adoption, restraining orders.



Real Estate

Residential & commercial purchases and sales, refinancing, title transfers, mortgage instructions, condominium reviews, builder transactions, ILAs.



Criminal Law

Bail hearings, impaired driving, assault, theft & fraud, drug offences, summary & indictable trials, sentencing submissions, appeals, record suspensions.



Immigration

Express Entry, PNP, sponsorship, work & study permits, citizenship, refugee claims, LMIA support, appeals to IAD, judicial reviews.



Wills & Estates

Wills, enduring powers of attorney, personal directives, trusts, probate & administration, estate litigation, succession planning, notarisations.



Notary Services

Affidavits, statutory declarations, commissioning of oaths, certified true copies, travel consents, notarised translations.

SECTION 03 — THE ENGAGEMENT LIFECYCLE

End-to-End Client Workflow

Every file at AA Legal flows through a disciplined 12-stage process designed to meet Law Society of Alberta standards, ensure consistent quality, and protect both the client and the firm.

1

Initial Enquiry & Lead Capture

Prospective clients reach us by phone, email (yemi.a@aalegal.ca), website form (aalegal.ca), referral, or walk-in. Every enquiry is logged in the CRM with source, matter type, and urgency.

- Multi-channel intake: phone, email, web, referral
- Same-day acknowledgement target
- Triage to the appropriate practice area

2

Conflict Check & KYC

Before any substantive discussion, we run a conflict-of-interest search against current and historical clients, and complete client identification under the Law Society's Client Identification & Verification Rules.

- Name, address, occupation, ID verification
- Source-of-funds enquiry where applicable
- Politically Exposed Person (PEP) screening

3

Consultation & Scope Definition

An in-person, telephone, or video consultation explores the client's objectives, legal issues, risks, and possible strategies. We provide a candid assessment of merits, costs, and timelines.

- 30–60 minute consult (free or flat-fee)
- Issue spotting & preliminary strategy
- Discussion of fees, billing & expectations

4

Retainer & Engagement Letter

A written retainer agreement defines scope, fee structure (hourly, flat, contingency, block), trust deposit, billing cycle, and the rights and duties of both parties.

- E-signed retainer (DocuSign / Adobe Sign)
- Trust deposit collected via Interac, cheque, or wire
- Trust ledger opened per LSA trust accounting rules

5

File Opening & Matter Setup

A new matter is created in the practice management system with a unique file number, deadlines calendared, document folder created, and the responsible lawyer / paralegal assigned.

- Matter plan & task list
- Limitation & court deadlines diarised
- Document templates pre-loaded

6

Discovery, Research & Document Collection

We gather evidence, financial disclosure, contracts, identification, corporate records, or whatever the file requires; conduct legal research; and prepare a working file plan.

- Secure client portal for document upload
- Statutory & case-law research (CanLII, Westlaw, Lexis)
- Witness interviews where applicable

7

Strategy & Drafting

The lawyer drafts pleadings, contracts, wills, agreements, letters of demand, or immigration applications. All drafts undergo internal QA before client review.

- Precedent library & clause bank
- Two-stage internal review
- Plain-language client summaries

8

Negotiation & Representation

We represent the client before opposing counsel, government agencies (IRCC, Land Titles), tribunals, or courts — pursuing settlement first where appropriate.

- Mediation & collaborative practice
- Court appearances & hearings
- Regular client status updates

9

Execution & Closing

Documents are signed, registered, filed, or submitted. Funds are disbursed from trust. Title transfers, divorce judgments, probate grants, or PR confirmations are obtained.

- E-signing & remote commissioning
- Trust disbursement with full reconciliation
- Registration with Land Titles, courts, IRCC

10

Billing & Collections

Time entries are captured daily; invoices are issued per the retainer schedule; trust funds are applied per LSA rules; outstanding receivables are followed up systematically.

- Detailed dockets & transparent narratives
- Electronic invoicing & online payment
- Monthly trust reconciliation

11

File Closing & Reporting Letter

Upon completion we issue a reporting letter summarising the work done, outcomes, and any ongoing client obligations (e.g., updating a will after major life events).

- Final reporting letter
- Return of original documents
- Closed-file archiving (10+ years per LSA rules)

Post-Engagement & Client Retention

We request feedback, invite Google reviews, schedule periodic check-ins (estate refresh, immigration renewal), and continue value-add via newsletters and seminars.

- NPS survey & testimonials
- Annual “legal check-up” reminders
- Referrals & alumni program

SECTION 04 — INTERNAL OPERATIONS

Functional Departments Behind the Practice

Behind every file is a coordinated set of operational functions that keep AA Legal compliant, profitable, and client-centric.

CLIENT SERVICES

- ◆ Reception & phone handling
- ◆ Appointment scheduling
- ◆ Walk-in greeting & intake forms
- ◆ Client portal access & support
- ◆ Multi-language coordination

LEGAL PRACTICE

- ◆ Lawyer file ownership
- ◆ Paralegal & clerk support
- ◆ Drafting & document review
- ◆ Court & tribunal appearances
- ◆ Continuing professional development

COMPLIANCE & RISK

- ◆ LSA Code of Conduct adherence
- ◆ Conflict checks & KYC
- ◆ Anti-money-laundering (FINTRAC)
- ◆ Insurance & ALIA reporting
- ◆ File audit & quality assurance

TRUST & ACCOUNTING

- ◆ Trust ledger management
- ◆ General ledger & bookkeeping
- ◆ Monthly bank reconciliation
- ◆ Annual LSA trust report

- ◆ Payroll & HST/GST filings

TECHNOLOGY & SECURITY

- ◆ Practice management system
- ◆ Cloud backup & encryption
- ◆ Cybersecurity & phishing defence
- ◆ E-signing & document automation
- ◆ Website & client portal

MARKETING & BUSINESS DEVELOPMENT

- ◆ Website & SEO
- ◆ Google Business Profile & reviews
- ◆ Social media & newsletters
- ◆ Referral relationships
- ◆ Community sponsorships & seminars

HR & ADMINISTRATION

- ◆ Recruitment & onboarding
- ◆ Articling student supervision
- ◆ Performance reviews

- ◆ Policy & handbook maintenance

- ◆ Office & vendor management

KNOWLEDGE MANAGEMENT

- ◆ Precedent & clause libraries

- ◆ Internal know-how database

- ◆ Practice notes & checklists

- ◆ CPD records

- ◆ Client FAQs & guides

SECTION 05 — CLIENT EXPERIENCE

The AA Legal Client Journey, At a Glance

A simplified visual of the path every client travels with us — from first contact to long-term relationship.

1

Discover

Find us via web, referral, or community

2

Connect

Enquiry logged & acknowledged

3

Consult

Initial meeting & assessment

4

Engage

Retainer signed, file opened

5

Work

Strategy, drafting, representation

6

Resolve

Outcome achieved & documented

7

Reflect

Feedback, review, refer

8

Re-engage

Future legal needs supported

SECTION 06 — PERFORMANCE

Key Performance Indicators We Track

< 4h

FIRST-RESPONSE TIME

≥ 95%

CONFLICT CHECK COVERAGE

100%

TRUST RECONCILIATION ACCURACY

≥ 4.8★

AVERAGE CLIENT RATING

≥ 70%

LAWYER UTILISATION RATE

< 30d

AVERAGE INVOICE AGING

0

MISSED LIMITATION DATES

≥ 40%

REPEAT & REFERRAL BUSINESS

SECTION 07 — GOVERNANCE

Regulatory & Compliance Framework

AA Legal operates within a strict regulatory ecosystem. Compliance is built into every workflow.

REGULATOR / AUTHORITY	SCOPE	AA LEGAL OBLIGATION
Law Society of Alberta (LSA)	Professional conduct, trust accounting	Annual reports, CPD, trust audits, Code of Conduct
Alberta Lawyers Insurance Association (ALIA)	Professional liability insurance	Active coverage, incident reporting
FINTRAC	Anti-money- laundering	Client ID, large cash & suspicious transaction reports
Office of the Privacy Commissioner (PIPA/ PIPEDA)	Client data protection	Privacy policy, breach reporting, secure storage

REGULATOR / AUTHORITY	SCOPE	AA LEGAL OBLIGATION
Canada Revenue Agency (CRA)	Taxation	GST/HST filings, T4/T5018, corporate tax
Court of King's Bench / Provincial Court of Alberta	Litigation procedure	Filing rules, court dress, deadlines
Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC)	Immigration matters	Authorised representative status, use of approved forms
Land Titles Office (Alberta)	Real-estate registration	Electronic registration credentials, fee schedules

SECTION 08 — TECHNOLOGY BACKBONE

Tools That Power the Practice

A modern stack underpins every department — chosen for security, compliance, and Canadian residency where possible.

PRACTICE MANAGEMENT

- ◆ Clio / PCLaw / CosmoLex
- ◆ Matter, time & trust in one system
- ◆ Court-rules engine for deadlines

DOCUMENT & KNOWLEDGE

- ◆ NetDocuments / iManage
- ◆ Microsoft 365 with Canadian tenancy
- ◆ Precedent & clause libraries

COMMUNICATION

- ◆ Encrypted email (TLS, S/MIME)
- ◆ Secure client portal
- ◆ Zoom / Teams for virtual meetings

E-SIGNING & ID

- ◆ DocuSign / Adobe Sign
- ◆ Persona / Onfido for KYC
- ◆ Remote commissioning where permitted

RESEARCH

- ◆ CanLII, Westlaw Edge, Lexis+ Canada
- ◆ Practical Law

- ◆ Internal knowledge base

ACCOUNTING & PAYMENTS

- ◆ QuickBooks / Xero integration
- ◆ LawPay / Clio Payments
- ◆ Interac e-Transfer, EFT, wire

SECURITY

- ◆ MFA on all systems
- ◆ Endpoint encryption & MDM
- ◆ Daily encrypted backups (Canadian region)

MARKETING

- ◆ WordPress / website CMS
- ◆ Google Business Profile
- ◆ Mailchimp newsletters

SECTION 09 — RISK & ETHICS

How We Protect Clients & the Firm

Confidentiality & Privilege

- ✓ Solicitor-client privilege protected by physical and digital safeguards
- ✓ Need-to-know access controls
- ✓ Confidential shredding & secure disposal
- ✓ NDAs with vendors handling client data

Risk Management

- ✓ Diarised limitation & deadline calendar
- ✓ Mandatory peer review on high-stakes drafts
- ✓ Cyber-incident response plan
- ✓ Annual compliance & ethics training

SECTION 10 — REVENUE MODEL

How AA Legal Earns & Bills

Fee structures are matched to the matter type and client need — always transparent, always disclosed in the retainer.

FEE MODEL	TYPICAL USE	CLIENT BENEFIT
Flat / Block Fee	Wills, real-estate closings, notarisations, simple immigration apps	Cost certainty
Hourly	Family litigation, complex estates, commercial disputes	Pay for actual effort
Retainer Replenishment	Ongoing litigation	Predictable cash flow on both sides
Limited-Scope (Unbundled)	Coaching self-reps, document review	Affordable, targeted help
Contingency (where permitted)	Select civil matters	No win, no fee
Pro Bono / Reduced Fee	Community service files	Access to justice



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Professionalism, Integrity and Compassion



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